CHAPTER 7 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Fort Wagner & the 54th Massachusetts

The assault that proved — before a watching nation — that Black soldiers would fight, and die, for freedom. July 1863.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

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Why did a battle the Union lost become one of the most important victories of the war?

The First to Be Asked

1863

After the Emancipation Proclamation opened the army to Black soldiers, the 54th Massachusetts Infantry became one of the first Black regiments raised in the North. Its men knew every eye in the country was on them — and that captured Black soldiers risked being killed or enslaved.

Led by a young white colonel, Robert Gould Shaw, the 54th volunteered for the most dangerous mission available: a frontal assault on Fort Wagner, a powerful Confederate stronghold guarding Charleston Harbor.

"Storming Fort Wagner" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, 1890, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Assault on Fort Wagner

JULY 18, 1863

At dusk the 54th charged across open sand into massed cannon and rifle fire. They reached the walls and fought hand-to-hand before being driven back.

"Storming Fort Wagner" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, 1890, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Defeat That Changed Minds

THE COST

The attack failed. Nearly half the regiment was killed, wounded, or captured, and Colonel Shaw died on the fort's wall, buried by the Confederates in a mass grave with his men — an insult they intended, which the North turned into a badge of honor.

Sergeant William Carney, though shot several times, kept the U.S. flag from touching the ground. Decades later he became one of the first Black Americans awarded the Medal of Honor.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

FREDERICK DOUGLASS, WHOSE OWN SONS SERVED

Once let the black man get upon his person the brass letters, U.S. … and a musket on his shoulder and bullets in his pocket, and there is no power on earth … which can deny that he has earned the right to citizenship.

Losing the Fort, Winning the Argument

WHY IT MATTERS

The 54th did not take Fort Wagner. But their courage, reported in newspapers everywhere, shattered the claim that Black men would not or could not fight. Enlistment of Black soldiers surged; by war's end nearly 180,000 had served.

This is why the battle is remembered as a victory: it was fought as much for public opinion as for the fort. The 54th proved, in front of the whole nation, that the fight for the Union and the fight for Black freedom were now the same fight.

The divided nation, 1861 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Weigh the Evidence of Valor

YOUR TURN

You'll read several sources about the 54th and practice corroboration — checking accounts against each other to explain how a lost battle reshaped a nation's mind.